The king, however, aspires to a different standard. He has 500 wives and concubines, and ‘whenever he sets eye on a beautiful woman or damsel, he takes her for himself’. Even then, he covets a beautiful wife of his brother —who rules a nearby kingdom and also keeps many wives— and one day succeeds in ‘ravishing her from him and keeping her for himself’. Naturally, war looms between the brothers, as it has many times before. Once again, their mother intervenes, knife in hand and pointing at her breasts, ‘If you fight with each other, I will cut off these breasts which gave you both suck.’ Her emotional blackmail succeeds once again; the brother who has lost one of his wives swallows his pride and war is averted. But it is only a matter of time, thinks Marco, before the mother is dead and the brothers destroy each other.

The region breeds no horses but imports them from Aden and beyond. Over 2000 steeds arrive on ships each year but, within a year, all but 100 die ‘due to ill usage’ and lack of horse-handling knowledge. Marco believes that foreign merchants ‘do not send out any veterinaries or allow any to go, because they are only too glad for many of the horses to die in the king’s charge’. Further north, in a little town near modern Chennai, is the tomb of St Thomas the Apostle, a place of pilgrimage for both the Christians and Muslims of the region. It’s likely that Marco also visited Mamallapuram. He marked its location on the map he carried but didn’t write about it.[3]

A few hundred miles north is the port of Motupalli, writes Marco. It’s part of a kingdom ‘ruled by a queen, who is a very wise woman’. Throughout ‘her forty years’ reign she has governed her kingdom well with a high standard of justice and equity’. Never was a ‘lady or lord so well beloved as she is by her subjects’. Marco is talking about Rudrama Devi of the Kakatiya Dynasty of Warangal in modern Telangana. This kingdom, he writes, is a huge producer of diamonds and buckram cotton of ‘the finest texture and the highest value’ and people here live on ‘rice, flesh, milk, fish and fruit’.

After the eastern Coromandel Coast, Marco sails up the western Malabar Coast, but his observations here are sparse. He speaks about Quilon (Kollam), which has ‘some Christians and Jews’. The people ‘make wine out of [dates], and a very good drink it is, and makes a man drunk sooner than grape wine’. Skilled astrologers abound, as do physicians, ‘adept at